

Elevance Payer Policy: MRI Lumbar Spine (Non-Contrast)

Policy Code: MRI_LUMBAR | Version: 2026-Q3 | Effective Date: 2026-07-01

Purpose: This policy defines the clinical evidence required to authorize a non-contrast MRI of the lumbar spine for adult patients presenting with low back pain or radicular symptoms.

Required Supporting Documentation:

1. Clinical notes from the ordering provider dated within the last 90 days, documenting the patient's presenting symptoms, duration, and severity.
2. Documentation of at least six (6) weeks of conservative therapy, including physical therapy records or a structured home exercise program, prior to the imaging request.
3. A written statement of medical necessity from the ordering provider explaining why advanced imaging is required at this time.
4. Any prior relevant imaging reports (X-ray, CT) if previously obtained for the same complaint.
5. Documentation of any red-flag symptoms (e.g. progressive neurological deficit, bowel or bladder dysfunction, suspected cauda equina syndrome), if present, which may expedite review.

Notes: Requests lacking conservative therapy documentation will be returned to the provider for additional evidence unless red-flag symptoms are clearly documented.